THE EGO IN CONTEMPORARY PSYCHOLOGY [1]

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I. Introduction

One of the oddest events in the history of modern psychology is the manner in which the ego (or self) became sidetracked and lost to view. I say it is odd, because the existence of one's own self is the one fact of which every mortal person—every psychologist included—is perfectly convinced. An onlooker might say, "Psychologists are funny fellows. They have before them, at the heart of their science, a fact of perfect certainty, the one warrant for the being of all other things, and yet they pay no attention to it. Why don't they begin with their own egos, or with our egos—with something we all know about? If they did so we might understand them better. And, what is more, they might understand us better."

Back in the 1880's, of course, it was good form for James, Royce, Dewey and their contemporaries to speak freely of the ego, the self, or even the soul. The soul, to be sure, was giving way under Wundt's onslaughts, and everyone was finding it exhilarating to shake off the alleged 'theological domination,' and to emerge unfettered and positivistic into the era of the New Psychology. They forgot that their predecessors had not endorsed the soul because of their theological leanings, but rather, because associationism did not recognize or explain to their satisfaction the *coherence*, *unity*, and *purposiveness* which they thought prevailed in mental life. Granted that the 'soul' also failed to explain these properties, it at least called attention to their existence.

After the expulsion of the soul, these unifying properties of mental life were occasionally referred to under the designa-

[1] President's address to the 14th Annual Meeting of the Eastern Psychological Association, Hunter College, April 30, 1943.

tion of 'self.' For a time, thanks to James, Calkins, Prince, and the French psychopathologists, 'self' was a reasonably popular concept. But gradually it too fell into disuse.

The total eclipse of soul and the partial eclipse of self were due in part, as I have just said, to the rise of positivism in psychology. Positivism, we all know, is a scientific program for moral re-armament, whose imperatives include absolute monism, absolute objectivity, and absolute reductionism—in short, absolute chastity. From this ascetic point of view, subjective certainties are suspect, selves seem a bit indecent, and any hint of metaphysics (that is, of non-positivistic metaphysics) savors of laxness. As Gardner Murphy pointed out to this Association one year ago there was no prestige to be gained from a psychology of the self (**39**).

But for all its sumptuary control, positivism had one undisputed merit: it engendered a wholesome dislike for question-begging explanations. Much of the older psychology, it showed, suffered from a tendency to labor over words as if words were the essence of things. Thanks to positivism faculty psychology, resting as it did on verbal realism, became discredited, and dialectics fell into disrepute. Much of self-psychology, we must now admit, dwelt on the unenlightening plane of dialectics. Its statements were often redundant or circular. In the manner of Gertrude Stein it sometimes asserted that a self is a self is a self. Not being, by nature, especially lyrical, psychologists failed to see any deeper significance in this exalted formula. Quite understandably they refused to admit such a stammering self to the gray citadel of their laboratories.

But when a concept becomes taboo it is probable that the taboo will irradiate to cover a whole range of problems associated with the concept. Something of this sort seems to have happened. It is not only the soul and the self that suffered ostracism, but along with them a vast array of problems having to do with the coherence and unity of mental life, with pride, ambition, and status, with values, ideals, and outlook on the future. The eclipse, of course, has not been total, but it has been considerable.

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As if to compensate for the neglect of these interests within the field of psychology proper, psychoanalysis rose upon the horizon emitting a spectacular, if sporadic, light. Small wonder that the world at large turned to psychoanalysis for guidance in dynamic psychology. There was precious little other guidance to be had. I am inclined to believe history will declare that psychoanalysis marked an inter-regnum in psychology between the time when it lost its soul, shortly after the Franco-Prussian War, and the time when it found it again, shortly after World War II.

Until psychoanalysis becomes finally fused into a broader and more adequate psychology, it may take pride in having preserved and advanced the study of certain functions of the self that positivistic psychology had consigned to oblivion. It may take credit too for preserving one term, more or less cognate with 'self,' from the dark taboo of which I have spoken. 'Ego' has featured prominently in psychoanalytic literature from its beginning. This term I am now appropriating to signify the recentering that is taking place in psychological theory.

But it is not from psychoanalysis alone that we draw our threads. The position of the ego in contemporary psychology is determined by certain other historical trends as well.

II. Main Conceptions of the Ego

Among the different conceptions of the ego found in psychological literature the following are certainly the most important:

1. *The ego as knower.*—The nominative form of the word ego implies that some subject is busily engaged as Brentano would say in 'intending' his relations to the universe. The problem of the knower or 'Pure Ego' has been of little interest to psychologists since James gave it his lengthy *coup de grâce* in the *Principles*. It is enough, says James in effect, to admit that knowing goes on. A separate knowing-ego is not a necessary assumption. For phenomenologists (**4, 42**) and personalists (*e.g.*, **37**), of course, the problem of the subject-object relationship remains uppermost. But for the

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most part, since the time of Brentano and James, psychologists have passed the problem by.[2] For our purposes, we need only record this first usage, and note its relative rarity.

2. *The ego as object of knowledge.*—Some investigators have set themselves the problem of the nature of our experience of the self (**2**, **22**, **33**). This approach, limited as it is to the deliverances of introspection, has not been particularly rewarding. It yields relatively unenlightening localizations for the ego which is felt to lie 'between the eyes,' or to consist of 'motions in the head,' or to be situated 'between right and left,' 'between up and down,' 'between behind and before.' Following this line of investigation Horowitz came upon such a diversity of results (reports locating the ego in the head, heart, chest, face, brain, genitals) that he concludes "the localization of the self as it is reported in the literature quoted, in the responses on our questionnaire, in informal discussion, in the investigation of children, is not the basic phenomenon one might hope for to ease an analysis of the structure of the self and personality" (**22**, p. 386).

There seem to be only two facts upon which there is general agreement. (1) Infants, all writers concur, do not recognize themselves as individuals; they behave in what Piaget calls an 'undifferentiated absolute' composed of self and environment. Only gradually and with difficulty does a segregated ego evolve. (2) The ego of which we are aware is variable in its dimensions. Sometimes it includes less than the body and sometimes more. In a semi-doze we lose all sense of our egos though we may be conscious enough of impersonal items. Our feet perhaps are suddenly perceived as strange objects not belonging to us. In pathological conditions, we know, remarkable experiences of depersonalization take place (**7**, **10**). Conversely, we sometimes think of a tool we are using as parts of our extended ego-system, and at

[2] Private correspondence with Koffka concerning his own usage of the term brought out the interesting fact that in writing his chapters on the ego he had never thought of ego in the rôle of the knower (**28**). "To be quite frank, I never put this question to myself." He adds, "That my solution will be similar to Brentano's I doubt. At the moment it seems to me that it will be found in the theory of Ego subsystems, more particularly in the relation of the Self-system to other Ego-systems."

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times we regard our children, our lodge, or our ancestors as an intimate part of our extended selves. It is agreed that in this manner the ego-systems of which we are aware contract and expand in a most variable fashion (**33**).

3. *The ego as primitive selfishness.*—A century ago Max Stirner wrote *Der Einzige und Sein Eigenthum* (**49**), a volume in which he developed the thesis that man is by nature unalterably egoistic. In 1918 the French biologist Felix Le Dantec handled the same theme more brilliantly in his *L'egoïsme: seule base de toute société* (**29**). Unquenchable egoism is the foundation of the social edifice, says Le Dantec, and hypocrisy is its keystone. Psychologists are partial to such hard-headed realism, and have themselves gone far in unveiling the hypocrisy in man's nature. Projections, rationalizations, defense mechanisms have been exposed for what they are—the whitewashing of ego-centric motivation. During this century psychologists have joined with historians, biographers, novelists in the fashionable sport of debunking human motives.

4. *The ego as dominance-drive.*—Related to this view of primitive egoism, we find many investigations that deal with dominance feelings, with ascendance, with pecking orders, with euphoria. From this point of approach the ego is that portion of the personality that demands status and recognition. The negative states of anxiety, insecurity, defensiveness, resistance are just as truly indicators that whenever the ego is debased there arise impulses for its defense and restoration to status.

5. *Ego as a passive organization of mental processes.*—Psychoanalysis, we all know, has contributed much to the interpretation of human nature in terms of egoism. Its whole theory of motivation is based upon the assumption of hedonistic self-interest. But in psychoanalysis egoism, oddly enough, is not ascribed to the ego, but to the urges arising from the id. For Freud the ego proper is a passive percipient, devoid of dynamic power, 'a coherent organization of mental processes' that is aware of the warring forces of the id, super-ego, and external environment (**16**). The ego, having no

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dynamic power, tries as well as it can to conciliate and to steer the warring forces, but when it fails, as it often does, it breaks out in anxiety. The ego is born of restraint of the instinctual impulses, and it continually needs strengthening. But even when through the analytic process it is strengthened, it is still essentially nothing more than a passive victim-spectator of the drama of conflict.

Dissatisfied with Freud's denial of dynamic power to the ego, we know that later psychoanalytic writers, French (**14**) and Hendrick (**20**) among them, have ascribed more *momentum* to the ego. It is the agent that plans, that strives to master as well as to conciliate the conflicts. One analyst, Heinz Hartmann, departing considerably from Freud, holds that "adaptation to reality—which includes mastery of it—proceeds to a large extent from the ego and in particular from that part of the ego which is free from conflict; and it is directed by the organized structure of ego-functions (such as intelligence, perception, etc.) which exist in their own right and have an independent effect upon the solution of conflicts" (**18**, p. 214). To such writers the ego-ideal is no longer, as it was with Freud, a passive reflection of the superego, which in turn is conceived as a mere legacy of the parent. The ego through its ideals reaches into the future, becomes an executive, a planner, a fighter.

6. *Ego as a 'fighter for ends.'*—We are brought then, by some of the more modern psychoanalysts to a position not unlike that of McDougall, or of James in his more teleological moments. For McDougall self-regard was the master and controlling sentiment in whose interest all other sentiments function (**34**, p. 383). The phrase 'fighter for ends' I borrow from James (**25**, I, p. 141), who at times was intensely dynamic and personalistic in his conception of the self.

The purposive view of the ego may be linked to Koffka's postulate that there is ever active "a force which propels the ego upwards" (**28**, p. 670). The position is represented too in those dynamic psychologies that recognize the subservience of the biological drives to one central drive of ego-satisfaction. One of the most forceful expressions of this point of view

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is to be found in Goldstein's *Human nature in the light of psychopathology.*[3]

7. *The ego as a behavioral system.*—In spite of his postulation of "a force which propels the ego upwards," Koffka's position is characteristically somewhat less dynamic than that just described. The ego, he says, is only one segregated system within an homogeneous field. Much behavior occurs with no reference to the ego. Not all perception, not all action, not all emotion, not all consciousness, are related to an ego-system. The ego varies widely in its boundaries from time to time, and under certain circumstances acts as a system which determines the course of events as does any other dynamic system according to the theory of Gestalt. But much of the time behavior is free from the influence of an ego-system.

More influential because of its experimental fruitfulness is Lewin's treatment of the subject (**31**, p. 181). Although he seldom uses the term ego he too allows for a central subsystem within the person. Not all behavior is ego-linked, but many kinds of experimentally obtained results cannot be accounted for without referring to the special types of tension that exist whenever the ego is 'engaged.' The shifting aspiration level is, most obviously, a phenomenon of ego-tensions. Satiation, substitution, encapsulation, resistance, irreality, power-field are among the Lewinian concepts whose characteristics represent various properties of ego-tensions.[4]

It is clear that Lewin, no less than Koffka, wishes to avoid thinking of the ego as a single entity, and prefers to regard it

[3] "On the basis of our discussion I believe we are in no way forced to assume the existence of special drives. . . . They are special reactions in special situations, and represent the various forms by which the organism as a whole expresses itself. . . . The traditional view assumes various drives which come into the foreground under certain conditions. We assume only one drive, the drive of self-actualization, but are compelled to concede that under certain conditions the tendency to actualize one potentiality is so strong that the organism is governed by it" (**17**, pp. 144 f).

[4] A particularly suggestive contribution of Lewin pertains to the difference between nationalities in terms of the relative ease with which the ego becomes 'engaged.' Thus the American is less defensive, less touchy, less reticent than the German, due to the fact that the barriers of the German's ego lie near the 'surface.' He protects himself against familiarity and intrusion; whereas the American leads a much more 'public' life and protects only the 'core' of his personal life from public gaze (**32**).

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as the variable set of forces that are aroused whenever the person enters into some novel and perhaps dangerous relation to his environment.

8. *Ego as the subjective organization of culture.*—In recent years, as everyone knows, there has been a drawing together of psychology, psychoanalysis and social anthropology. The resulting commensalism has produced a new conception of the ego. The picture of the selfish and unsocialized ego bequeathed us by Stirner and Le Dantec has been broadened. Sherif, for example, points out that although the ego is a 'genetic psychological formation,' yet it is acquired by the child under the ceaseless impact of influence by parents, teachers, and associates, with the result that we must say that the ego "is chiefly made up of social values" (**48**, p. 179). Since the process of segregating the ego in childhood is achieved largely by giving the child a name, a status, a code of behavior, a social sense of guilt, and social standards for making his judgments—Sherif concludes that the ego is nothing but the social part of man (**48**, p. 186). This author's position is extreme, for if the ego is nothing but 'the social in man,' one wonders what to call all the anti-social impulses and the solitary strivings that are normally called *egoistic?* Cantril's view is similar to, but less extreme than, Sherif's. Cantril admits that "a person's ego and, consequently, the way in which he regards himself, are by no means always entirely bound by the surrounding culture" (**5**, p. 44). But yet what an individual regards as himself is undeniably, in large part, socially determined. When his nation's flag is torn down *he* is insulted; when disparaging remarks are made of his parents, *he* is involved; when his political candidate loses a contest, *he* has been defeated.

By stressing the cultural content of the ego, these authors in effect eradicate the artificial Freudian distinction between ego and superego. They also rescue the ego from the anti-social solipsism of Stirner and Le Dantec and make of it a socialized agent ready to enter as an integrated unit into the complex relations of social life.

From this historical glance I have omitted many writers

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who have made their contribution to the literature of the ego. But, nevertheless, I believe, I have mentioned the chief ways in which, up to now, the ego has been conceived, viz., (1) as knower, (2) as object of knowledge, (3) as primordial selfishness, (4) as dominator, (5) as a passive organizer and rationalizer, (6) as a fighter for ends, (7) as one segregated behavioral system among others, (8) as a subjective patterning of cultural values.

The question immediately arises as to whether these eight uses of the term ego have anything in common, or whether, as is often the case, a single term is allowed to obscure entirely different problems. Is the ego as knower the same ego that seeks status? Is the me that is known also a fighter for ends? Has the ego system proposed by Koffka any kinship with Freud's ego who attempts through insight to reclaim the id?

These are questions that cannot yet be answered. We cannot say whether these eight conceptions reflect irreconcilable theories, whether they shade imperceptibly into one another, or whether they are all ultimately to be subordinated under one inclusive theory of the ego.

In favor of the last possibility I should like to point to recent experimental studies which, if I mistake not, lend support to several of these conceptions simultaneously. The experiments result in one common finding, namely, that ego-involvement, or its absence, makes a critical difference in human behavior. When a person reacts in a neutral, impersonal, routine atmosphere, his behavior is one thing. But when he is behaving personally, perhaps excitedly, seriously committed to a task, he behaves quite differently. In the first condition his ego is not engaged; in the second condition it is. And it is my belief that in most of the experiments I shall report one finds that the ego is acting in several, if not all, of the eight capacities I have listed. In other words, *ego-involvement* is, as the phrase implies, a condition of total participation of the self—as knower, as organizer, as observer, as status seeker, and as socialized being. But now for the experimental evidence.

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III. Experimental Evidence

1. *Generality and specificity.*—A few years ago I found myself involved in a controversy in the field of personality. Certain experimenters claimed that their findings demonstrated a situational specificity in human conduct. For example, a child, honest in one situation, would not be found honest in another (**19**); a person confident of one judgment would not be confident of another (**53**). Whole books were written in defense of specificity (**50**). Other investigators, by other methods, found a person honest in one situation to be honest in another (**35**); a person confident in one judgment to be confident in another (**26**); and whole books were written in defense of generality (**1**). It was a pleasant battle while it lasted. An arbitrator arose, a peacemaker by temperament—Gardner Murphy was his name—and he proposed a compromise. "Honesty," he suggested, "is either a general characteristic or a set of specific habits, depending on your interest and your emphasis" (**38**, p. 385). Murphy was right, but it was not until recently that the deciding interest and critical emphasis became clear at least to me. For my own belated insight I am indebted to an experiment by Klein and Schoenfeld (**27**).

These investigators gave to a group of subjects a series of mental tests under two experimental conditions. In the first, the atmosphere was neutral, dull, *non ego-involved.* The workers were merely laboratory subjects going through routine motions. After each of the six tests they were required to rate the degree of confidence they felt in the accuracy of their performances. Between the six tests there was little consistency in these certainty ratings. After an interval of time, a second equivalent set of tests was administered and the atmosphere was markedly changed. The subjects were placed under greater strain, were told to try hard since the results of these 'intelligence' tests would be entered on their college records. The shift in atmosphere was effective. The confidence ratings became markedly consistent. A student who felt assured in one test felt assured in the other five;

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whereas a student who lacked confidence in one of his performances generally lacked confidence in the other performances. The authors conclude that confidence is a personality trait when the ego is involved, but that it is specific to each situation when the subject has no deep interest at stake.

This experiment supplies the hypothesis needed to settle a long-standing controversy. When there is ego-involvement there are general traits; when there is no ego-involvement there are no general traits.

From an entirely different source comes evidence of the same type. In connection with its polling investigations the Office of Public Opinion Research has found that *intensity* of feeling goes with *consistency* of opinion (**6**, Ch. 3). For example, in the pre-Pearl Harbor era it was found that those who felt most intensely in favor of aid to Britain were, by and large, those who endorsed all sorts and varieties of interventionist propositions. On the other hand, those who were lukewarm in their support of aid to Britain were far more inconsistent and specific in their answers. Sometimes they gave interventionist, and sometimes isolationist, replies. The measure obtained between the intensity scale and the generality of the attitude was a coefficient of correlation of +.63.

2. *Judgment.*—Eli Marks worked on judgments of skin-color among Negroes. He found it, in part, to be a function of the objective scale but, in part also, a function of an egocentric scale. A Negro of medium coloration is likely to be judged dark by a Negro of lighter complexion, and as light by a Negro of darker complexion (**36**). For decades psychophysicists have dealt with judgments of hue as a function of wave length, but Marks makes clear that judgments of hue may be also a function of one's sense of social status. Wave length is perceived by the sensitized retina, but it is perceived no less by the sensitized ego.

In the field of simple predictive judgment, it was found in the public opinion polls of 1940 that of the people who were strong Willkie supporters, 71 per cent predicted that he would win the election; of those who were weak Willkie supporters,

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only 47 per cent made this prediction (6). Assuming as we must that intensity of an attitude indicates ego-involvement, we find here a clear quantitative demonstration that a 24 per cent difference in the number of predictions exists when the ego-regions of the presonality are engaged. Admittedly, the ego's wish is only one factor in predictive judgments, but if conditions are right it can become the crucial factor as it did in these 24 per cent.

Polling research has uncovered yet another important fact concerning judgment. If you ask respondents to tell you to your face what they think about our allies, the British, or about some minority group in this country, or even about their own educational level, you obtain one set of results; but if you ask them to write their answers to the same questions privately and deposit them in a padlocked ballot box, on the average your results will be significantly different (6, Ch. 5). Now this difference between open and secret expressions of opinion seems to exist only when the answers might jeopardize the respondent's sense of status or affect his prestige in the interviewer's eyes. The discrepancy is great enough to warrant the use of secret balloting whenever questions are of a type that might expose the person to humiliation.

Judgments concerning one's self are remarkably interesting things to study. We know, for example, how inaccurate people are in rating their own economic status. Nearly all prefer to overlook the objective evidence and to identify themselves with the great middle class (6). We know something about the distortions that result when people report their own traits. Frenkel-Brunswik found the self-protective devices so powerful that her subjects would omit, justify, or completely reverse the facts, in their accounts of their own deficiencies (13). Although it is trite to point out what all psychologists know so well, that lack of objectivity is the rule when our egos are involved, yet it is not trite to remark that very little work has been done on the extent and nature of the distortion, nor upon the curious and momentous question why it is that some personalities attain objectivity even in

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the face of extreme ego-involvement. Insight, it would seem, grows more and more difficult to achieve as the inner regions of the personality are approached. And yet some individuals accomplish remarkable feats of self-objectification. Why do they succeed and others fail?

3. *Memory.*—Thanks to Bartlett we know how cultural schemata alter our memory traces (**3**). Here, of course, is an example of the silent influence of an ethnocentric frame. But within any given culture striking memory-efforts can be traced to egocentric frames as well.

Edwards has demonstrated that if memory material fails to fit comfortably into an ego-involved frame, it contorts itself until it does so. Using three groups of students, each with a different attitude toward the New Deal (favorable, neutral, or opposed) he first read them a 10-minute passage concerning the relations of the New Deal to communism. The subjects knew they were to be tested for the accuracy of their retention.

> Immediately after the reading, a multiple choice recognition test consisting of 46 items was given to the subjects. Half or 23 of the items on the test were answered in the passage in a manner favorable to the New Deal, the other 23 were answered in a manner unfavorable. The items on the test offered opportunities for rationalization of one's answer, if the correct answer was opposed to one's attitude. The subjects were re-tested after an interval of 21 days.
>
> Analysis of variance of the data showed that rationalization was directly associated with the degree of conflict between the correct answer and the attitudinal frames of reference of our subjects. In general the results show—as do many other studies—that it is almost impossible to expect objectivity and accuracy in perception, learning, remembering, thinking, etc., when ego-involved frames of reference are stimulated (**9**, p. 234).

Here one might cite also the memory experiments of Zillig which show how members of the male sex recall fewer aphorisms favorable to women than to men (**58**). Or, the Watson and Hartmann study concerning the distortions that occur in memory for theological arguments depending upon the subject's previous commitment to atheism or to theism (**56**). Or, Wallen's ingenious demonstration that after an interval of time subjects recall ratings of their own personalities in a

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manner that makes them compatible with their own preconceived opinions of themselves (**54**).

In a recent investigation Levine and Murphy demonstrated that pro-Communist sympathizers memorize pro-Communist textual material more easily than they do anti-Communist textual material (**30**). What is more, they forget the antipathetic text more rapidly and more completely than the sympathetic text. In anti-Communists the effects are exactly reversed. It was a brilliant stroke for these authors to demonstrate in one experiment that both learning and forgetting are functions of the political identifications of the ego.

4. *Frame of reference.*—Some of the studies I have mentioned have been conducted in relation to what their authors have called a 'frame of reference.' Now, a frame of reference seems to signify *any spatial-temporal or cultural orientation, that relates many of an individual's attitudes, habits and judgments to one another, and influences the formation of new judgments, attitudes, and habits.* A general orientation favorable to the New Deal will, according to Edwards, determine our specific remembrance of items from speeches concerning the New Deal (**8**). A general orientation regarding various other subjects, Sells has shown (**47**), will affect our logical reasoning in all matters pertaining to them.

Now it is important to note that not all frames are ego-involved. If I locate 9th Avenue or East 12th Street readily it is because I have a geographic frame in mind for New York City. In my case this spatial orientation is not at all ego-involved. The point I am making is that research on the problem of frames of reference is not necessarily research on the problem of ego-involvement. Many cultural frames having to do with language, etiquette, or dress, determine our perceptions, our memory, our conduct, but their influence is not felt as personally relevant. Margaret Mead has expressed her anthropological astonishment at the odd custom Americans have of appearing at her lectures with clothes on; but to most of us this quaint folkway causes no ego-concern, at least as long as it is operative.

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But an interesting discovery has come to light in these days of war and violence. Certain cultural frames which were previously indifferent have suddenly become acutely personal. Probably no one in Alsace felt concerned about the bilingual frame of reference until the Nazis decreed that only German should be spoken, and that only Germanized names and inscriptions should appear on the tombstones. Bilinguality had always been taken for granted, but when this familiar, habitual frame was suppressed and placed under attack, then it became of central importance, and people reacted as to a personal insult. Many of us have recently discovered that hitherto indifferent frames of reference, such as the Constitutional guarantees we enjoy, previously taken for granted, have suddenly become ego-involved, and now in jeopardy are defended as if they were parts of our physical bodies. Suppose we in this room were forbidden to speak the English language. How enraged we would become. What had always been a mere ethnocentric frame would immediately become ego-involved.

Ethnocentric and egocentric frames both affect our conduct, and, as I have just pointed out, under certain conditions the ethnocentric frame is experienced also as an egocentric frame. But I think it is a mistake to confuse the concept of the ego with that of the socius (or cultural portion of our personalities) as Sherif has done. Under normal social conditions only a relatively small portion of our culture is ego-involved.

5. *Learning.*—The longest and most difficult chapter in psychology, no one will deny, is the chapter on learning. The latest Yearbook of the National Society for the Study of Education is devoted entirely to this subject (41). One searches its 463 pages in vain for any mention of the ego, and almost in vain for any recognition of the importance of *interest.* True, one finds occasional remarks to the effect that "the teacher who neglects the simple but powerful word of praise does so at her pedagogical peril" (41, p. 118), but the potential significance of such remarks for learning theory seems lost to view.

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Clinical, educational, and industrial psychologists know that the first rule of all applied psychology is that every child and every adult needs some experience of success and social approval. John E. Anderson advises the teacher to go far out of her way if necessary to find an area in which these feelings can be engendered, and he adds

> Success in one area may more than compensate for failure in many areas; some accomplishment furnishes an integrating center about which the personality may be integrated (41, p. 349).

Note especially Anderson's statement that "success in one area may more than compensate for failure in many areas." Only in terms of ego-psychology can we account for such fluid compensation. Mental health and happiness, it seems, does not depend upon the satisfaction of *this* drive or *that* drive, it depends rather upon the *person* finding *some* area of success *somewhere*. The *ego* must be satisfied, not the hunger drive, nor the sex drive, nor the maternal drive, however temporarily insistent these segmental tensions may be.

Now most theories of learning lean heavily upon the assumption of multiple drives. A segmental tension exists, the organism behaves, the tension is relieved, and the response set. In this sequence it is often assumed that all drives are equally potent for learning. The satisfaction of any drive, through the principle of reward or confirming reaction, is held to bring about an equal degree of learning. If this is so, how can we account for the fact that praise is found almost uniformly to be the leading incentive in school, in factory, and in ordinary life? If we are to hold to the theory of multiple drives at all, we must at least admit that the ego-drive (or pride, or desire for approval—call it what we will) takes precedence over all other drives.

Not only does human learning proceed best when the incentive of praise and recognition is used, but the individual's *capacity* for learning actually seems to expand under this condition. Every psychometrist knows that in order to obtain a valid I.Q. the subject must be encouraged. Terman's instructions on this point are well known.

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Nothing contributes more to a satisfactory *rapport* than praise of the child's efforts. . . . In general, the poorer the response, the better satisfied one should appear to be with it. . . . Exclamations like fine! splendid! etc., should be used lavishly (52, p. 125).

In other words, to maximize the child's intelligence we must maximize his ego. For psychological theory this is really a momentous fact. Intelligence is the ego's tool for solving its own problems. It is manifestly unfair to estimate intelligence on the basis of performance in which the individual himself has no interest. For this reason, through the device of praise, the subject must be encouraged to make the test-items into ego-involved problems which he can attack with maximally motivated effort. Intelligence is the individual's capacity to solve problems of importance to himself.

There is one unfavorable condition for learning that must be admitted lest we oversimplify the issue. Too intense an ego-involvement may be disruptive. Its normal integrative value may be actually undetermined when eagerness or self-consciousness reach a degree of intensity that lead to embarrassment or over-anxiousness. No one learns or performs well if his autonomic nervous system is in a turmoil. We need a rule that will help us determine the optimum degree of ego-involvement required for enhancing efficiency of learning and performance.[5]

One word about the law of effect. Its principal shortcoming, I think, stems from the assumption that rewarded *responses* tend to recur. Many experiments, in fact, show that rewarded responses do not blindly recur whenever an appropriate stimulus returns. Hoppe (21) points out that people normally do not strive again for a goal successfully achieved. What they do is to raise their aspirations to a point where they clearly risk failure. A student who makes an A record in a course in college, shows no tendency to repeat that course. He prefers to take new risks in the same

[5] One formulation of the needed rule is suggested by French: "So long as the tension does not exceed the available energy of the integrative mechanisms, so long will the integrative capacity of the goal-directed striving increase with increasing tension. But as soon as the tension of the need begins to exceed the available energy of the integrating mechanism, the effect of increasing tension will be the opposite" (15, p. 245).

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general area. And an experiment by Rosenzweig indicates that it is definitely infantile to choose to repeat successful acts (46). For example, a puzzle once solved, even if accompanied by a burst of elation, no longer attracts the mature individual. He wants new worlds to conquer. Reward may bring merely satiation and boredom.

The fallacy, I repeat, lies in our speaking of rewarding a *response*. The law of effect would be truer if it held simply that a *person*, being rewarded, employs his past successes in whatever way he thinks is likely to bring him satisfaction in the *future*. Israeli has shown that, excepting for certain psychopaths, people are much more interested in their futures than in their pasts (24). Since this is so, an individual's past performances often mean little or nothing to him. Only if the ego would be served thereby, does he engage in a repetition of the successful act. More often he chooses to vary and refine his behavior so that he may feel that he himself is growing toward new successes in the future.

The relation between success and repetition, I suspect, is much closer in the case of non ego-involved behavior than in the case of ego-involved behavior. Over and over again I use the same motor combinations in typewriting, in driving my car, in dealing with tradesmen. They are reasonably successful acts; why should I change them? But I do not repeat successful research work, do not repeat a gratifying conversation with a friend, nor do I re-state the same goal in an aspiration-level experiment. Ego-involved tasks often demand changing goals and new responses. Rewarded behavior, it would seem, becomes stereotyped only in lower animals, or in such human activities of a routine nature that fail to engage the ego.

To summarize this brief discussion, it would seem that in order to employ the law of effect with human learning we must view it as secondary to the principle of ego-involvement. The law of effect, like cue reduction, conditioning, bond-formation, and most other popular principles of learning, have been worked out for the most part on animal subjects or on human beings deprived for the duration of the experiment, of their

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egos. The principles may be good ones, but I submit that when the ego is engaged they operate in a contingent fashion. Learning theory of the future, let us hope, will not remain so peripheral to the ego.

6. *Motivation.*—You may be thinking, "But, we've always known that one must be motivated in order to secure a response. Are you talking about anything more than the importance of motivation?" Yes. I am saying that there are two forms of motivation, one ego-involved and one not, and I am attempting by repeated citations from experiments to show the differences that exist between them.

Take, for example, the work of Huntley and Wolff on judgments based upon records of expressive behavior (**23, 57**). These investigators working independently instructed their subjects to make judgments concerning the personalities of many people from their handwritings, from their recorded voices, from photographs of hands, and from their style of story telling. The subjects were motivated in a routine manner as is any laboratory subject. But, suddenly, in the midst of the series they were confronted with samples of their own expressive behavior which had been recorded without their knowledge. In the large majority of cases the subjects did not consciously recognize their own records and continued innocently with their characterizations. But something had happened. The characterizations began to take a different form. Even though a judge was wholly unaware that a certain expression was his own, he gave it a much more favorable rating than he gave similar expressive records taken from other subjects. Occasionally he gave it a vehemently unfavorable rating, but practically never did he give it an indifferent rating. Other people's records might arouse no affect, but not his. Whenever a subject became half-conscious, as it were, that a record might possibly be his, his judgments were still more intensely partisan; but when he fully recognized his own record then his social sense of modesty prevailed, and his judgments returned to the noncommital level.

In these experiments we have a particularly neat demon-

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stration of the fact that ego-involved systems may operate in a wholly silent manner, affecting judgments in a most extreme way without the subject knowing the reason. The experiments also prove that the limen of ego-involvement is lower than the limen for self-recognition, an interesting finding which warns us once more that conscious report and introspection will never be a sufficient method for exploring the operations of the ego-system. But the important point for our present purposes, is to note that routine motivation to perform a task is one thing, and that ego-charged motivation is quite another. Routine motives yield one set of results, ego-motives a different set.

When is motivation ego-involved and when is it not? A partial answer seems to lie in the degree of frustration involved. As we have already noted many customary frames of reference are not felt to be personally relevant, and do not behave like egocentric frames, until their continuance is threatened (as in wartime). Many drives, too, run their course without engaging the ego unless they are interfered with. But serious frustration may instigate the clamor, the jealousy, the possessiveness, often characteristic of ego-involvement. And yet frustration by no means always produces this effect, especially if one has compensated for drive-frustration by success in other realms. And then, to complicate the situation further, we cannot say that ego-involvement is absent when there is no frustration. Many smooth-running instances of goal-seeking behavior are obviously ego-involved. A mother feels just as closely identified with her child when it is in good health as when her maternal care meets with frustration. A business man is as much absorbed in his enterprise in times of prosperity as he is in times of adversity. Let us say, then, that frustration of goal-seeking behavior or any kind of threat to the individual, is very likely to engage the ego-system; but that normally this ego-system is made up of the ordinary values which spell out the significance of life to the individual.

7. *The level of aspiration.*—The history of ten years' research on this Lewinian problem is too intricate to trace

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here, but unless I am mistaken every investigation has directly or indirectly confirmed Hoppe's initial claim that the subject behaves in such a manner as to maintain his self-esteem at the highest possible level (21). Of course, many investigators have not used the conception of the ego at all. Yet whatever results are found they all seem to point to the essential inescapability of Hoppe's original hypothesis. Frank (11) for example, found that subjects in whom 'self competition, and consciousness of social pressure' were present, had D-scores three to seven times as large as did subjects who had no such sense of personal involvement in the situation.[6] Frank also found that subjects who are ego-involved do not change their estimates with every little variation in their performance. They try and try again before trimming their aspirations to fit their capacities; subjects not ego-involved on the other hand, quickly yield to the immediate realities of the situation, and lower their aspiration level (12). We know too that competitiveness, surely a symptom of ego-involvement, usually produces a rise and greater consistency in the aspiration level (43). But we cannot say that competitiveness always has this effect because subjects who dread competition will lower their level of aspiration consistently in order to avoid the risk of humiliation (11). In short, it seems always to be the ego-demand of the individual subject that determines the behavior of the aspiration level. Some subjects are adventurous, some cautious; their egos demand different types of satisfaction, and it is this fact that is repeatedly reflected in the results of the experiments. It is worth pointing out that historically the aspiration level may well be regarded as the door by which the ego re-entered the cloisters of academic psychology.

8. *Industrial psychology.*—Most of us, I suppose, have been impressed in recent years by the demonstrations of Roethlisberger and Dickson (44), of Watson (55), and others, that employees in industry are not 'economic men' so much as they are 'ego men.' What they want, above all else, is

[6] D-scores, of course, indicate the discrepancy between performance and the goal that the individual wishes or expects to achieve.

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credit for work done, interesting tasks, appreciation, approval, congenial relations with their employers and fellow workers. These satisfactions they want even more than high wages or job security. Now, the employer's estimate of the worker's wants correlates just about zero with the worker's own report of his wants (**55**, p. 119). The employer thinks that wages and security are the dominant desires, whereas in reality the ego-satisfactions are primary. What a different outlook there would be on our economic life if we took firm hold on the issues of status and self-respect in industry, and re-planned our industrial society in a manner that would rescue the worker's ego from oblivion.

IV. The Nature of the Ego

In the experiments I have cited, and in many others of analogous nature, it turns out that one group of subjects (those who are personally aroused and committed to a task) behave in ways quite unlike other subjects (who are not so committed). In some instances there are measurable quantitative differences as great as 50 or 60 per cent, sometimes much more. In other instances there are qualitative changes that elude measurement. In short, we are here confronted with some parameter that makes a vast difference in our experimental results.

We have seen that under conditions of ego-involvement the whole personality manifests greater consistency in behavior, reveals not specificity in conduct but generality and congruence. In the field of judgment, we have seen how ego-involvement results in significant distortions of the ordinary psychophysical scales. In memory, we find that retention is characteristically superior (though at times repressions also may be more likely to occur, and rationalizations may creep into ego-involved memory). In intelligence, we note that ego-involvement is indispensable if we would obtain optimum performance. In learning theory, reforms seem indicated to make room for the demonstrable influence of the ego upon the acquisition of skill and knowledge. In motivation, the craving for recognition, status, and personal ap-

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preciation turns out to be supreme, so much so that our conceptions of procedure and policy in industrial relations, in education, and in psychotherapy, are profoundly affected. And these are only a few of the operational criteria by which we may demonstrate the existence of the ego.

Its admittance to good standing in contemporary psychology has been advocated by several psychologists besides myself. Koffka, Lewin, and the psychoanalysts have done so; as has Murray who makes a distinction between 'peripheralist' psychology and 'centralist' psychology (40). The thesis set forth in Roger's recent book *Counseling and psychotherapy* (45) seems to me especially clear evidence that the ego is coming into its own. Rogers, in effect, asks counselors to sit back and with little more than an occasionally well-placed *m-hm*, to encourage the patient himself to restructure and re-plan his life. The patient's ego takes command. It's about time it should.

Although we have given an adequate operational demonstration of the ego, we have not yet faced the difficult problem of definition. Earlier we saw that eight conceptions seem to prevail. But whenever we encounter ego-involvement the ego in several of its historical senses seems to be active. Furthermore, these historical conceptions seem to have much in common.

For one thing, it seems clear that all of the conceptions are less embracing than 'personality.' All writers seem agreed that the ego is only one portion, one region, or as the Freudians say, one 'institution,' of the personality. Many skills, habits, memories are components of personality but seldom, if ever, become ego-involved. Writers seem also agreed that the ego is non-existent in early childhood, evolving gradually as the child comes to mark himself off from his environment and from other human beings. They seem also to agree in viewing the ego as the portion of the personality that is in proximate relation to the external world. It senses the threats, the opportunities, and the survival significance of both outer and inner events. It is that portion of the personality, so to speak, that meets the world head-on. It is

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the contact-region of the personality. For that reason it is also the conflict-region. Yet it is coextensive with neither consciousness nor with unconsciousness, for much that we are conscious of is indifferent to our egos, and many unconscious stimuli silently but effectively engage them.

There is also agreement that the subjective sense of the ego varies greatly from time to time, now contracting to include less than the body, now expanding to include more. Its content keeps changing, for at certain moments the ego seems preoccupied with one activity and soon thereafter with a wholly different activity. This shifting scene however does not mean that there is no stable and recurring structure. On the contrary, if you know a person well enough, you find that you are able to predict with marked success what items will and what items will not be linked to his ego. By many writers the ego is represented as a layered structure. Certainly there are *degrees* of ego-involvement. A person may be intensely partisan or moderately partisan.

There seems to be one other property of the ego, less often discussed, namely its customary preoccupation with the future. Israeli, it will be remembered, reports that among his subjects over ninety per cent expressed themselves more interested in their futures than in their pasts (**24**). This finding is worth stressing, for as a rule, psychologists are more interested in a person's past than in his future. In other words, the psychologist and his subject customarily face in different directions, and that is unfortunate.

V. Psychology During the War and After

You and I are ego-involved in the course of the war and in the outcome of the future peace. Likewise, for different reasons, we are involved in the development and progress of psychology as a science and as a profession. Now it is typical of the generalizing tendency in the ego that matters having a high degree of personal relevance do not ordinarily remain apart. They tend to become fused into an integrated plan of action. Thus, in order to help win the war approximately a thousand psychologists have transferred their pro-

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fessional activity to camps, factories, or government offices. And most of those who have remained in colleges have rearranged their lives in such a way as to blend their war interests with their professional activity.

Although it is too early to evaluate the work we all are doing, I wonder if you have the same impression I have concerning the utility of our previous training in psychology. It is my guess that insofar as our war work deals with sensory, perceptual, and psychometric problems, the transfer value of our previous psychological training is very high. But insofar as our war work deals with problems of morale, public opinion, national character, scapegoating, ideology, guidance, rehabilitation—any of the areas where the major hates, fears, and hopes of men are concerned—the transfer value of our previous training is much less. In other words, the psychology that treats the non-ego involved functions of the human organism has developed to a point of immediate utility, whereas the psychology of the 'central' regions of personality has not. I make this statement with full appreciation of the admirable work of our colleagues in OSS, in OWI, FBIS, and in other similar bureaus. But most of them, I think, would agree that the psychology available for application to their problems has shown itself to be both meagre and inept.

It might be argued that, being a young science, psychology has moved, as it were, from the surface inward. Given time we shall have as much to contribute to an understanding of the central layers as of the surface. But is it merely a matter of time? Is it not rather that the sumptuary regulations of our science have been unhealthy for the ego?

Everywhere we encounter the paradox: As a group, psychologists are liberal, internationally minded, and devoted to the welfare of the common man. They believe in providing a soil where the infinite varieties of the human ego may freely grow. At the same time their assumptions, their methods, their theories have not been well suited to the attainment of their objectives.

For the past ten years we have become increasingly aware of this paradox. As evidence, there is the mounting tide of

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experiments of the type I have reviewed. As further evidence, there is the widespread recasting of our activities in wartime and the notable turning of psychologists' interests to the formulation of conditions for a lasting peace (**51**). In all this work there is a somewhat novel co-operative spirit. The coming Inter-Society Constitutional Convention is one instance of what I have in mind. As never before we seem to desire to have our productions fit together. Ego-satisfactions, we are discovering, are not necessarily competitive. One is reminded here of the experiments of Helen Lewis (unpublished) which have demonstrated that *your* tensions may be resolved by *my* work and *my* tensions may be resolved by *your* work, provided only that we regard ourselves as co-operating members in a common undertaking.

The admittance of the ego to good standing in psychology does not mean a re-importation of the *deus ex machina* of pre-Wundtian psychology. It does mean, however, a recognition of the fact that our predecessors who regarded psychology as the science of the soul, were not wrong in setting the problems of unity and personal relevance before us. What they called the soul, we may now, with good conscience, call the ego. In so doing, no clocks need to be set backward. Dialectics has already given way to experiment and to the clinic, and to still newer methods for studying the common man in his normal social setting.

But disregarding the problems of method, which are beyond the scope of my paper, we may safely predict that ego-psychology in the twentieth century will flourish increasingly. For only with its aid can psychologists reconcile the human nature that they study and the human nature that they serve.

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